2.1 The Middle Ages

For hundreds of years, the Roman Empire united much of Europe. So when the western part of the empire fell in A.D. 476, its laws and social structures collapsed, too. With the empire no longer in control, "Now what?" could well have been the question on almost everyone's mind.

MAIN IDEA During the Middle Ages, Western Europe underwent many political, economic, and social changes.

A FEUDAL SOCIETY

Political, economic, and social problems led to the decline of the Western Roman Empire. As the empire weakened, Germanic tribes from Northern Europe invaded Western Europe and overthrew the emperor.

The end of the Western Roman Empire signaled the beginning of a period known as the **Middle Ages**, which lasted from about A.D. 500 to 1450. With no central government after the fall of Rome, Western Europe largely consisted of small kingdoms ruled by Germanic tribes, such as the Franks, Visigoths, and Vikings. Over time, the kingdoms grew and became very powerful.

To help the leaders of these kingdoms hold onto their land and protect their subjects, a political and social system called **feudalism** developed. Feudalism helped ensure the defense and security of kingdoms, which were constantly at war with one another. It achieved this security by maintaining a strict social **hierarchy**, or order.

Kings sat atop this structure. They gave pieces of their land to noblemen, known as lords. A lord, in turn, granted parts of this land to lesser noblemen called **vassals**. Vassals paid taxes on the land and pledged their military service to the lord.

Structure of Feudal Society



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The Plague Doctors

When the bubonic plague swept through medieval Europe in the 1300s, medical science was still 500 years away from understanding its cause. At that time, some doctors believed the plague was spread by bad air or odors. In the 1600s, a French physician created the costume, shown here, to protect against such odors and supposedly against the plague. But the problem was not odors. The problem was infected rats and their fleas. Rats spread throughout medieval cities, which lacked sanitation. Fleas living on the rats spread the disease by biting people. The victim then often suffered swelling, vomiting, back pain, delirium, and, finally, death.



Many vassals themselves were soldiers in the army and served as knights, who were warriors on horseback. Peasants called **serfs** were at the bottom of the heap.

The **manor system** emerged as a result of feudalism. The system consisted of peasants bound to a lord's land, or manor. Landowners maintained a tight grip on both their land and their workers, while the peasant workers received a level of military protection they could not provide for themselves. Feudalism and the manor system remained in place throughout the Middle Ages, providing some stability to Western Europe.

WARS, TRADE, AND TOWNS

Still, feudalism was not the only source of stability. The Roman Catholic Church served as the strongest unifying force in medieval Europe. Late in the 11th century, the Church waged the **Crusades**, wars against the spread of **Islam**. That religion's followers, called **Muslims**, had seized control of the Holy Land—the city of Jerusalem and the surrounding area. They'd also begun to attack the Christian Byzantine Empire, once the eastern half of the Roman Empire.

The Crusades continued for two centuries, allowing Crusaders to acquire land in areas previously conquered by Muslims. The land acquisition led to the establishment of trade centers. Though the Crusaders were ultimately unsuccessful—they eventually lost any land they captured—their actions increased trade between Europe and the eastern Mediterranean region.

As trade increased in Europe, businesses and the economy grew. Towns grew, too, as people left their positions on the manors for better jobs.

Outbreaks of a devastating disease called the bubonic plague also created jobs. In the 14th century, the plague killed as many as one-third of all Europeans. Those laborers lucky enough to survive the illness found better work prospects as a result of the decline in population. Less competition led to greater opportunities for those who survived.

The plague, along with the movement to cities and towns, helped bring about the decline of feudalism and the end of the Middle Ages. Europe began to experience cultural changes that would mark the beginning of a new age of creativity.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How are the manor system and feudalism similar to each other?
2. **EVALUATE** In what way were the Crusaders both successful and unsuccessful?
3. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How did feudalism and the Church affect Europe similarly and differently?

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